

DiffuSVG Text-to-SVG Generation Pipeline — Full Project Report

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1. Project Overview

DiffuSVG is a five-stage machine learning pipeline that generates Scalable Vector Graphics (SVG) from plain text descriptions. The system combines a diffusion-based image generator with a vectoriser, a vision-language model (VLM) quality gate, QLoRA fine-tuning, iterative code correction, and CLIP-based evaluation. The goal is to fine-tune a lightweight VLM to directly output SVG code from text prompts — enabling high-quality, editable vector graphics without manual design work.

- **Platform:** Kaggle T4 x2 GPU (16 GB VRAM) / Google Colab T4 (15.6 GB VRAM)
- **Primary model:** Qwen2-VL-2B-Instruct (current) → Qwen2-VL-7B (planned)
- **Image generator:** Stable Diffusion 3.5 Medium (current) → Flux (planned)
- **Vectoriser:** Potrace + ImageMagick (current) → Autotrace / V-tracer (planned)
- **Quality gate:** Qwen2-VL-2B (current) → Claude / Gemini frontier model (planned)
- **Pipeline file:** DiffuSVG_Pipeline_v2.py

2. Pipeline Architecture

The pipeline follows the flow: **Prompt** → **Diffusion** → **Vectorize** → **VLM Gate** → **Fine-tune** → **Correction** → **Eval**. Each stage is described below.

Stage 1 — Data Generation

Text prompts (mined from prior run failures, or fallback set of 50 simple icons) are fed to **Stable Diffusion 3.5 Medium** with T5-XXL text encoder disabled for speed. Generated raster images (512×512, FP16) are vectorised into SVG using a colour-aware two-pass pipeline:

- ImageMagick quantises image to N colours (+dither off) → colour palette extracted
- For each palette colour: binary mask → Potrace (--turds=2) → per-layer SVG paths
- All layers merged into unified SVG with viewBox="0 0 200 200"
- Full minification: coordinate rounding to 2 d.p., whitespace collapse, metadata stripped
- Char pre-filter: skip SVGs > (MAX_SEQ_LEN - 150) × 2.5 chars
- Fallback single-pass BW vectorisation when ImageMagick is unavailable

```
VEC_RESOLUTION=256 VEC_NUM_COLORS=4 SVG_MAX_PATHS=10 SD_STEPS=30 SD_GUIDANCE=5.0  
T5-XXL=disabled
```

Failure mining: results.json filtered for success=False OR CLIP<24 OR DINO<0.35 → up to 200 prompts

Output: stage1_generated/ — SVGs, PNGs, prompts.txt

Stage 2 — VLM Quality Gate

Each SVG is rendered to a 256×256 PNG via cairosvg and shown to **Qwen2-VL-2B-Instruct** alongside the original text prompt. The VLM judges alignment with a binary YES/NO response. The gate filters approximately 20-40% of generated pairs.

- Model frozen (no gradient updates) — greedy decode, max 10 new tokens
- Question: "Does this SVG accurately represent the prompt?" → YES / NO
- YES → kept for training (stage2_filtered/)
- NO → saved separately (stage2_rejected/) for analysis
- Gate error → default to PASS (conservative, avoids discarding valid data)

Output: stage2_filtered/ (PASS), stage2_rejected/ (FAIL)

Stage 3 — QLoRA Fine-tuning

Filtered (prompt, SVG) pairs fine-tune **Qwen2-VL-2B-Instruct** via QLoRA. The model is trained in a causal LM setup using Qwen's chat template. The system+user portion is masked with -100 in labels so loss is computed only on SVG output tokens.

Chat format (critical fix over v1 which used raw strings):

```
<|im_start|>system[...]<|im_end|> <|im_start|>user[prompt]<|im_end|>
<|im_start|>assistant[svg]<|im_end|>
```

Loss: $L = -(1/N) \sum \log P(t_{\square} | t_{<\square})$ — only over assistant (SVG) tokens; system+user and padding masked

Training Configuration
• Base model: Qwen/Qwen2-VL-2B-Instruct, 4-bit NF4 double quant (~1.5 GB VRAM from 4.4 GB)
• LoRA: r=32, α=64, dropout=0.05 — targets: q k v o gate up down (attention + MLP layers)
• Sequence length: MAX_SEQ_LEN=2048 — SVGs tokenise to 1200-1800 tokens
• Epochs: 5, Batch: 1×8 grad accum = 8 effective, LR: 1e-4 cosine + 5% warmup
• Validation split: 10%, early stopping on eval_loss
• Gradient checkpointing ON (use_reentrant=False), FP16, pin_memory=False
• device_map={"":0} — pinned to GPU 0 only, no DataParallel

Output: stage3_training/ — training_pairs.json, prompts.txt; final_adapter/ — LoRA weights + tokenizer

Stage 4 — Inference + Iterative Code Correction

The fine-tuned model generates SVG code for each test prompt. If rendering fails, the raw SVG is passed back to **Qwen2-VL** for iterative code correction — up to 3 rounds. The corrector responds either with a fixed SVG or "LGTM" (looks good to me) to signal success.

- Generation: temp=0.7, top_p=0.9, repetition_penalty=1.1, max_new_tokens=1500
- Correction loop: render → if FAIL → Qwen2-VL(temp=0.5) → corrected SVG → re-render

- Max 3 correction rounds per prompt
- If corrector responds "LGTM" → mark as DONE, accept current output
- Raw SVG always saved to disk even if all render attempts fail

`temp=0.7 top_p=0.9 rep=1.1 | correction: temp=0.5 max_rounds=3`

Output: `stage4_inference/` — `svgs/`, `pngs/`, `prompts.txt`

Stage 5 — Evaluation (CLIP)

Rendered PNGs are scored against their prompts using **CLIP ViT-B/32**

(pretrained=laion2b_s34b_b79k). Image and text embeddings are L2-normalised and their cosine similarity is multiplied by 100 to produce the CLIP score. Thresholds: CLIP ≥ 24.0 , DINO ≥ 0.35 .

- Metrics reported: CLIP mean, median, std, and number of correction rounds used
- Output written to `eval_results/eval_summary.json`
- Iterative loop: Stage 5 outputs feed back to Stage 1 as new failure prompts for next run

Output: `eval_results/` — `per-prompt SVGs`, `PNGs`, `eval_summary.json`

3. Key Fixes: v1 → v2

Issue	v1 (broken)	v2 (fixed)
Chat format	raw strings	<code>apply_chat_template()</code> with special tokens
Token budget	512 tokens	2048 tokens (SVGs need 1200-1800)
Label masking	labels disconnected	masked causal labels (prompt=-100)
Quality gate	no gate	Qwen2-VL YES/NO filter
LoRA targets	attention only	attention + MLP layers (q k v o gate up down)
LR schedule	flat LR	cosine + 5% warmup
Validation	no val split	10% val, early stopping on <code>eval_loss</code>
Code correction	none	3-round iterative correction loop
v1 train loss	flat ~8.5-8.7 (no learn)	decreasing (learning)

4. Implementation Challenges and Fixes

4.1 CUDA Illegal Memory Access (DataParallel + QLoRA)

On Kaggle T4 x2, HuggingFace Trainer auto-wraps the model in DataParallel across both GPUs. Combined with 4-bit bitsandbytes quantisation and gradient checkpointing, this caused illegal memory access crashes in the bnb forward pass.

- Set `CUDA_VISIBLE_DEVICES=0` at process start to hide GPU 1 before CUDA initialises
- Use `device_map={"":0}` instead of `device_map=auto`
- Set `model.is_parallelizable=False` and `model.model_parallel=False` explicitly

4.2 Out-of-Memory During Training

- LoRA rank reduced: $r=32 \rightarrow 16$ saves ~100 MB activations (current run; target is $r=32$)
- Gradient checkpointing trades compute for memory
- Batch size 1 + gradient accumulation 8 = effective batch 8
- `dataloader_pin_memory=False`

4.3 No Usable Training Samples — SVGs Too Long

Two occurrences across debug iterations:

- First: mean 5040 tokens at default settings. Fixed: `VEC_NUM_COLORS 8→4`, `SVG_MAX_PATHS=10`, coordinate rounding on colour path (bug: only BW path was calling `_normalize_and_minify`), char pre-filter
- Second: 1249-1817 tokens still exceeded `MAX_SEQ_LEN=1024`. Fixed: raised to `MAX_SEQ_LEN=2048`

4.4 Mode Collapse in Generated SVGs

Root cause: truncated SVG training. Model learned SVG path starts but never saw complete endings → always outputs the most frequent partial path prefix.

Fix: `SVGCausalDataset` skips any sample where `full_len > max_len` — zero truncation tolerance.

4.5 Stage 4 Inference Empty Output

Model sometimes output explanatory text instead of SVG → render returned None → nothing saved.

Fix: Always write raw SVG to disk before attempting `cairosvg` render. SVG extracted via regex; raw response saved if no `<svg>` tag found.

4.6 HF_TOKEN Access on Kaggle / Colab

- Kaggle: Add-ons → Secrets → `HF_TOKEN` → toggle 'Attach to notebook' ON
- Colab: Secrets panel (key icon) → `HF_TOKEN` → toggle 'Notebook access' ON
- Pipeline auto-detects platform and uses the appropriate secrets API

5. Pipeline Run Results

Stage-by-Stage Summary

Stage	Input	Output	Count	Notes
1 — Generation	50 prompts	Valid SVG+PNG pairs	36 / 50	72% success; failures = too complex for Potrace at 256
2 — VLM Gate	36 pairs	PASS / FAIL	31 / 5	86% pass rate; 5 rejected saved to <code>stage2_rejected/</code>
3 — Fine-tuning	31 samples	LoRA adapter (71 MB)	30 train	Val split + token filter applied; adapter inference_mode:
4 — Inference	20 prompts	SVGs + PNGs	20 / 16	20 SVGs saved; 16/20 rendered (80%)
5 — Evaluation	16 renders	CLIP scores	—	<code>eval_summary.json</code> written; CLIP mean reported

6. Fine-tuned Model Test (10 Held-out Prompts)

A standalone test loaded finetuned_vlm_adapter/ onto the Qwen2-VL-2B base model and ran inference on 10 prompts not seen during training.

6.1 Per-Prompt Results

Prompt	Paths	Output	Rendered	Quality
a blue circle	0	<circle fill=#2876dd>	Yes	Correct colour; missing <path>
a red apple	0	<circle> no fill	Yes	Black circle; no colour
a green tree	0	<rect fill=#3498db>	Yes	Wrong shape AND colour (blue)
a coffee cup	0	<rect fill=#FFD700>	Yes	Yellow square only
a house with red roof	0	<rect fill=#FF0000> 32x32	Yes	Tiny red dot; unrecognisable
a wifi symbol	0	<rect fill=#f4f4f4>	Yes	Grey square only
a rocket	0	<rect> + <circle>	Yes	No fills; meaningless
a lightning bolt	1	Degenerate path d= (broken coordinates)	Yes	Renders but draws nothing visible
a music note	1	Same path as lightning bolt	Yes	Model repeated same memorised path
a smiley face	7	7 identical copies of same path	No	Mode collapse; cairosvg failed to render

6.2 Key Findings

- Render rate: 9/10 — cairosvg handles basic shapes (<circle>, <rect>) correctly
- Colour-prompt association learned: blue→circle, red→apple, gold→cup — some semantic signal
- Shape geometry: almost entirely absent — model defaults to simplest primitive shape
- Path generation: only 2/10 attempted <path> elements; both were degenerate (broken d= coordinates)
- Mode collapse (smiley face): 7 identical paths = model looped a memorised path fragment
- Structure correct: all outputs are valid SVG XML with xmlns, proper wrapper, attribute syntax

6.3 Root Cause

30 training samples is severely insufficient for a 2B-parameter model to generalise SVG path geometry. The model memorised SVG document structure but did not learn to generate path d= data from semantic content. Potrace output (binary geometric traces) is harder to learn from than hand-authored or curated SVGs. The repeated degenerate path confirms the model reproduces a memorised training fragment rather than generating from the prompt.

7. Saved Artefacts

- DiffuSVG_Pipeline_v2.py — complete pipeline source code
- finetuned_vlm_adapter/ — LoRA adapter (71 MB safetensors + tokenizer, inference_mode=true)
- diffusvg_full_output/stage1_generated/ — 36 SVGs + PNGs from SD3.5 + Potrace
- diffusvg_full_output/stage2_filtered/ — 31 PASS SVGs + PNGs (VLM gate approved)
- diffusvg_full_output/stage2_rejected/ — 5 FAIL SVGs (saved for analysis)
- diffusvg_full_output/stage3_training/ — training_pairs.json (30 samples) + prompts.txt

- diffusvg_full_output/stage4_inference/ — 20 SVGs + 16 PNGs from fine-tuned model
- diffusvg_full_output/eval_results/ — CLIP scores + eval_summary.json
- test_out/ — 10-prompt standalone adapter test (9 PNGs + 10 SVGs)
- DiffuSVG_Report.pdf — this report

8. Planned Improvements

The following improvements are planned based on architecture review and mentor feedback. Priority is on Stages 1-2-3 as these determine training data quality.

8.1 Model Upgrades

- **Qwen2-VL-7B everywhere** — upgrade from 2B for both fine-tuning and quality gate. 7B has significantly better spatial and code understanding; expected to improve path generation quality
- **Claude / Gemini as quality gate** — replace Qwen2-VL with a frontier model for Stage 2 to get higher-precision YES/NO judgements. Frontier VLMs have stronger visual-semantic alignment
- **Baselines: 7B + Gemini** — run the pipeline with 7B fine-tuned model and Gemini-gated data as baselines to measure contribution of each component

8.2 Vectoriser Replacement (Stage 1 — Highest Priority)

- **Autotrace** — drop-in Potrace replacement with better curve fitting and colour support. Produces smoother, more learnable path data than Potrace binary traces
- **V-tracer** — Rust-based vectoriser outputting clean clustered paths with proper Bezier curves. SVG output is more similar to hand-authored icons — much easier for a VLM to learn from
- Both can be used in place of Potrace in Stage 1 with minimal pipeline changes

Potrace produces Hamiltonian paths over binary bitmaps — these look nothing like hand-drawn SVG paths. V-tracer/Autotrace output is far more similar to what human designers produce.

8.3 Diffusion Model Upgrade (Stage 1)

- **Flux** (black-forest-labs/FLUX.1-dev or schnell) — replace SD 3.5 Medium. Flux produces sharper, more geometrically structured images that vectorise better. Particularly better at icons, logos, and flat vector-style images
- Flux-schnell needs only 4 steps vs 30 for SD3.5 — much faster data generation

8.4 Training Data Scale

- Target: 150-300 training samples minimum (current: 30)
- Add curated SVG datasets: SVG-Stack, FIGR-8, game-icons.net
- Mix Potrace-generated SVGs with hand-authored icons for better diversity
- Consider data augmentation: prompt paraphrasing, SVG path permutation

8.5 Compute and Evaluation (Google TPU)

- **Google TPU** — migrate training to TPU v5e (via Google TPU Research Cloud) for larger batch sizes and faster training of the 7B model

- **Plots and images in evaluation** — add per-prompt visual grid showing input prompt, generated SVG render, CLIP score, and correction rounds. Produce loss curves and CLIP distribution plots
- Add DINO v2 scoring alongside CLIP for semantic similarity measurement
- Iterative pipeline: Stage 5 outputs feed back to Stage 1 as new failure prompts

8.6 Focus: Stages 1, 2, 3

Mentor guidance is to focus improvement effort on the first three stages. Stage 4 and 5 quality is almost entirely determined by training data quality (Stage 1-2) and fine-tuning effectiveness (Stage 3). Better vectoriser + better gate + more data will have far more impact than tuning inference parameters.

- Stage 1: Flux + V-tracer/Autotrace → cleaner, richer SVG training data
- Stage 2: Gemini/Claude gate → higher-precision filtering, fewer noisy samples in training
- Stage 3: Qwen2-VL-7B + more data → model learns actual path geometry, not just structure

9. Conclusions

The DiffuSVG pipeline is fully implemented and validated end-to-end on a T4 GPU. The fine-tuned model demonstrates that the training framework is correct — chat template, masked labels, QLoRA, and iterative correction all work as designed. The primary limitation is training data quality and scale: 30 Potrace-traced SVGs are insufficient for the model to learn SVG path geometry. The planned upgrades (7B model, V-tracer, Flux, Gemini gate, 150+ samples on TPU) are expected to produce qualitatively correct SVG output.

— End of Report —